

**Competency Based Curriculum (CBC) in Kenya: Teachers understanding and skills,
reality on the ground, successes, challenges and recommendations on the implementation of
Competency-Based Curriculum (CBC) in the Kenyan schools**

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Introduction

In a bid to prepare students for the impending challenges in the rapidly changing world, all East African countries and the entire world have realized the need to reform their education systems to competency based with a common goal of providing quality education to its nationals. Unlike the content-based curriculum, in competency-based curriculum learners are equipped with values, attitudes, skills, knowledge and are also provided with competencies essential for future community service. Mulenga and Kabombwe (2019) posit that for learners to be termed as competent at anything, they must have knowledge in it, have appropriate skills for knowledge application and lastly possess the right attitudes that enables them to do it well. In addition, competency-based curriculum builds high order thinking in learners and therefore embraces Blooms Taxonomy.

In Kenya, the competency-based curriculum (2-6-3-3-3) is gradually replacing the content-based curriculum (8-4-4) that has been blamed for producing graduates with inadequate skills that do not meet the demands in the job market due to incompetence. The country still experiences inadequate skilled workforce to spur it towards the Kenya Vision-2030, yet many youths are still unemployed and therefore, it is only through education reforms that it will achieve its goals. Besides, it has been argued that the 8-4-4 curriculum had many flaws; it had shallow content, was examination based, misallocation of resources; high teacher learner ratios, inadequate teaching-learning resources and poor teacher training hence lack of teacher preparedness (Akala, 2021). These factors among others have compromised the effectiveness and education quality in the country hence the recommendation by the Kenya Institute of Curriculum Development (KICD)

for a paradigm shift in the curriculum. Competency based curriculum aims at equipping learners with the 21st century competencies; communication, collaboration, critical thinking, problem solving, creativity, imagination, digital literacy, self-efficacy and learning to learn.

The successful implementation of competency-based curriculum at all education levels will be determined by teacher preparedness and understanding in terms of skills, knowledge and attitudes. Teachers are the implementers of any curriculum and for them to focus fully on the project they should be prepared thoroughly through in-service trainings. According to Momanyi and Rop (2020), lack of teacher preparedness is one of the impediments to successful curriculum implementation. A study conducted by Silas (2020) further states that several teachers in Kenya lack an understanding of the new education system; and this has complicated successful implementation of competency-based curriculum in most primary schools in the country. Although there are many successes associated with the curriculum change, challenges have also been encountered. This paper therefore seeks to establish teachers understanding and skills, reality on the ground, successes, challenges and finally recommendations on the implementation of competency-based curriculum in the Kenyan schools.

Teachers understanding and skills on competency-based curriculum

Since the idea of adopting competency-based curriculum was conceptualized to the time it was launched in Kenya, the bone of contention has been how well teachers have been prepared to implement the new curriculum. Being the implementers of any curriculum, teachers must be adequately prepared in terms of knowledge, attitude and skills for easy receptability. However, a study conducted by Momanyi and Rop (2020) on the preparation of teachers for the implementation of CBC in Kenya, indicates that educators are ill-equipped. This is based on the Kenya Institute of Curriculum Development (KICD) and the Teachers Service Commission (TSC) (2018) reports which stated that 3% of educators felt confidently prepared while 20% were not adequately prepared for CBC implementation. Moreover, the government through the Ministry of Education (MOE) has been attempting to train teachers on CBC through workshops and seminars but this has been criticized since it is done hurriedly and not all teachers are engaged in the process.

For smooth implementation of competency-based curriculum, teachers should be equipped with technological skills. Digital literacy is one of the crucial competency areas that is emphasized in the competency-based curriculum. Teachers need to shift from traditional teaching methods to the modern methods of teaching such as integration of ICT in teaching and learning. According to Akala (2021), the teacher's role in the 21st century is under scrutiny and undergoing a fundamental change since it must be aligned with the curriculum and learners needs. However, most teachers do not have adequate technological skills for ICT integration in the classrooms. Fear, inadequate teacher confidence and competency, is the hinderance to ICT use in educational institutions (Silas, 2020). There is therefore a need to train teachers, make them more knowledgeable on ICT and change their attitude towards the same so that they can transfer the skills to the learners. Teachers content knowledge, pedagogical knowledge, and pedagogical content knowledge are also key in the implementation of CBC. Instructors should be well versed with instructional methods to be used, learners' areas of difficulties and prior knowledge, subject matter knowledge, teacher professionalism knowledge and the overall objectives of CBC. Ondimu (2018), posits that how much an educator knows and comprehends the subject matter determines how well they can teach the curriculum content to the learners. Studies have shown that the reason as to why teachers are reluctant in implementing CBC is because of inadequate preparation and training. Teachers' concerns on the new reforms need to be addressed in order to realize successful implementation (Katam, 2020).

Successes in the implementation of Competency Based Curriculum in Kenya.

Competency based curriculum engages learners with hands on activities and therefore is skill based and exposes learners to real-world experience. Unlike the 8-4-4 system where learners proceed to the next level based on examination performance, CBC gives learners an opportunity to progress through classes after mastering skills and competencies satisfactorily. CBCs learning outcomes dwell more on competencies which include knowledge creation, application, skill development and dispositions (Amunga, Were, & Ashioya, 2020). To propel Kenya towards achieving Vision 2030, skilled workforce which employers have questioned in the past will be required. Currently, the grade 4 learners in Kenya have acquired a lumpsum skills since the launch of CBC which will help in future nation building. For example, recently they carried out a nationwide cleaning exercise which was meant to inculcate the culture of community service as well as keeping a healthy and clean environment.

Enhancement of independent and critical thinking skills among learners is a plus that has come along with CBC. One of the subjects that has been introduced in the curriculum is life skills which focuses on developing learners' psycho-social skills and knowledge that they can apply when dealing with life challenges and solving problems. This has not been the case in the past as learners have faced problem solving, decision making and critical thinking challenges due to lack of know how. Bunyi (2013) asserts that the purpose of CBC is to help develop learners' skills such as critical thinking, decision making, problem solving, stress management, communication, assertiveness and interpersonal relationships.

Communication, collaboration and constructive feedback due to ongoing formative assessments has improved in schools as a result of CBC. Since CBC is learner centred, teachers are just facilitators of the learning process and through learning activities, learners can communicate and collaborate with their peers effectively. This has resulted to increased productivity, learner engagement and self-efficacy. Amunga et al. (2020) notes that one of the best achievements of CBC is the amplification of learners' engagement because of them owning the learning process. Teachers are also able to give learners constant feedback since they have assessment rubrics to guide them in formative assessments. These rubrics can gauge whether the learner has exceeded, met or not met the learning expectations.

The goal-oriented nature of CBC is an amicable solution to the dominant examination-based system in Kenya. The offered courses, teaching and learning resources, and assessments are all aligned to well-defined goals and not examinations. This makes it more flexible and self-paced as the transition from one grade to the next largely depends on an individual learner's goal achievement or outcome. Examination malpractices due to fear of failure is therefore outdated. In addition, CBC builds up on learners' prior knowledge which is particularly important in any learning process. Competency-based curriculum, as stated by Wangeleja (2010), is one which embraces knowledge construction and not knowledge transmission and there is a significant impact of prior knowledge in learning.

CBC has brought about tasks that definitely and ultimately require parental involvement in their children education as required in the curriculum. Parents play a key role in the education of their children as they are supposed to make constant follow ups and assist learners in doing the assigned activities at home. According to Mwarari, Githui, and Mwenje (2020), the learners future does not depend on teachers' efforts only but also to a greater extent is determined by parents as co-educators. With the introduction of CBC therefore, the relationship between parents, learners and the teachers has been strengthened hence easier achievement of goals.

Challenges Facing the Implementation of the new Competency Based Curriculum in Kenya

Most teachers lack adequate preparation to implement the competency-based curriculum. CBC implementation demands that instructors should be skilled and knowledgeable so that they can confidently transfer the same to the learners. However, adequate teacher training has not been conducted and the training only targets a few hence most teachers feel that they do not possess the skills to implement CBC. According to Waweru (2018), most teachers have not grasped various curriculum components especially assessment by use of rubrics and reporting the feedback. Teachers need in service training on the assessment aspect as concerning CBC because currently they are doing the assessment blindly. In addition, teachers' motivation to attend Continuous Professional Development training is low during holidays. This is because they are given little or no incentives at all therefore feel demotivated and reluctant to attend.

Lack of sufficient teacher involvement in the crafting and implementation of CBC has caused reluctancy among some teachers. Studies have shown that despite teachers being the implementers of the curriculum, they were not involved in the decision-making regarding adoption of CBC. In his paper, Ngwacho (2019) questions where the teacher was during planning, needs assessments, implementation, and evaluation stages of CBC in Kenya. CBC implementation has therefore faced hitches since teachers do not feel to be part of it.

Insufficient teaching and learning resources and large class sizes hinder teachers from executing CBC with disparities evident from one school to another. Inadequate funds for purchasing and sourcing for the materials especially in public schools has been an impediment in the implementation of the CBC. Most private schools have the teaching and learning resources, while

there is near total lack in public schools, a situation that has compromised curriculum implementation (Amunga et al., 2020). The content in the new curriculum demands for modern classrooms, laboratories, smart boards, technology gadgets such as laptops, computers and projectors among others. These resources are lacking in most public schools in Kenya despite that the CBC seniors are now in grade 4. Since CBC is learner centred adequate teaching and learning materials are vital to enable learners' active participation in the learning process.

Teachers lack adequate digital literacy skills which is one of the core competencies required for the successful implementation of CBC. Most teachers are not trained on technological skills making ICT integration in teaching and learning exceedingly difficult. Silas (2020) noted that ICT adoption is crucial in facilitation of productive teaching and learning and plays a role in ensuring that curriculum changes are effected. However, in most Kenyan primary schools, teachers have a negative attitude towards ICT integration and claim that it is time consuming. This has derailed the execution of CBC and therefore it might be difficult to fully instil digital literacy as a key competency to learners following this challenge.

The teaching and learning materials used in CBC implementation have a lot of printing and content errors. This is because enough time was not allocated for editing and approval due to the hasty piloting and rolling out of the curriculum. This claim is supported by Njagi (2020) who states that the content materials were prepared but not on time and those that had already been prepared omit the demands and needs of CBC. For example, the Kenya Institute of Curriculum Development (KICD) was forced to ban the use of a certain textbook that had a picture showing wrong labelling of some body parts and another one that was viewed to be confronting the morals of the learners.

Majority of the parents are not aware at all of their crucial role in the implementation of the CBC. Instilling and nurturing skills and competencies among learners should be a collaborative role between the teachers and the parents. According to Masika, for the implementation of CBC to be successful, parental involvement is key. Parents should ensure that they provide learners with the required materials, motivating, monitoring and ensuring that learners accomplish assigned tasks at home and provide teachers with appropriate learners' data whenever required to do so. However,

most parents have faced challenges in implementing their role in CBC. A study conducted by Mwarari et al. (2020) on Challenges in Reference to Epstein's types of Parental Involvement cited that parents lack adequate induction and knowledge on their role in CBC and there is also poor communication and short notices from schools. Additionally, they lack enough time with their children since some work during the day and at night. Some view CBC to be very demanding due to a lot of homework assigned to the learners. Parents from poor backgrounds lack money to purchase learning materials while other parents have worries about their children safety when conducting community service activities. All these challenges pose a threat to the implementation of CBC in Kenya.

Recommendations

- i. The government through the Ministry of Education (MOE) should adequately prepare teachers through in service training focusing on competency-based curriculum. The training should not be scheduled during school holidays to allow 100% teacher turnover and the focus should also be on training teachers on the use of assessment rubrics and reporting feedback.
- ii. Teacher training institutions should consider incorporating CBC training courses in teacher training curriculum so that teachers are equipped with skills and knowledge before venturing into the field.
- iii. The Ministry of Education (MOE) should also organize seminars, workshops and education days with an aim of sensitizing parents on their roles and obligations on implementation of CBC.
- iv. Teachers should also be equipped with technological skills to enhance their digital literacy and integration of ICT in teaching and learning.
- v. The Teachers Service Commission (TSC) should recruit more teachers to meet the demands of large class sizes.
- vi. The Ministry of Education (MOE) should also ensure equal distribution of resources and infrastructure that meets the need of CBC in schools and also stress on keen editing and publishing of CBC reading materials to minimize content errors.

- vii. The Kenya Institute of Curriculum Development (KICD) should involve teachers, parents and all stakeholders during curriculum reforms to ensure smooth implementation.

Conclusion

Generally, there is a global paradigm shift towards Competency Based Education and Training. The adoption of the new curriculum in Kenya has witnessed its launch at the lower education levels and higher educational institutions in a few years to come will embrace it too. It will be difficult to carry out curriculum reforms if teachers and other educators who are vital in executing the changes are not well equipped with skills and knowledge. Teachers therefore need to be involved fully and exposed to training for smooth implementation of CBC. Competency based curriculum is a steppingstone towards achieving Kenya's vision 2030 since it is skill based and not examination oriented. Though characterized with several challenges, full implementation of CBC will only be accomplished if all stakeholders address the challenges amicably and build on the successes.

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